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Race So Far

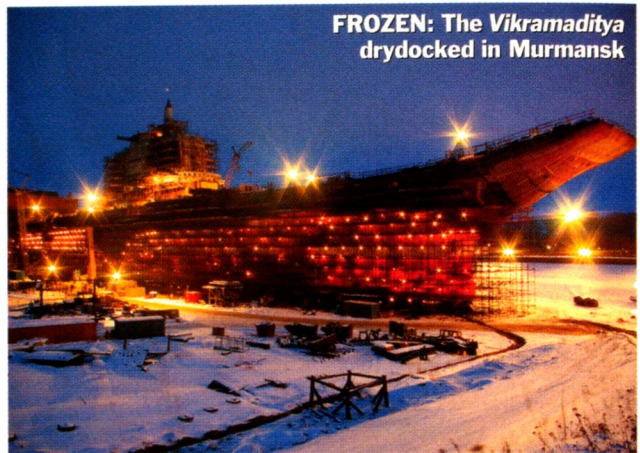


Opinion polls have already written the first draft of history. Any revision—or subversion—will be carried out on Election Day. And for once—you may have already noticed—the word ‘election’ is losing its political everydayness and assuming a kind of religious loftiness. And he is not that one but the One, the Inevitable One, and you must be a bloated, bigoted philistine if you ever try to make him one of us, to make him one of the mortal majority. In the colour of his skin, you must see the depth of otherness in a nation that has been sliding into a dangerous, paranoid exclusiveness. In his temperament—cool, composed, serene—you must see the solidity and trust you expect from the leader of the free world. In the resonance of his language, you must hear the voice of the philosopher king, and it’s a voice that uplifts the spirit after eight years of the presidential bombing of the English language. He is the avatar America has been waiting for. So, stand up and salute the unifier, the healer, the elucidator, the future... and ask no questions.

Barack Obama, the Democratic candidate and the favourite of political bookies, is on the verge of being canonised—no matter however prematurely—as Our Son of Salvation. Endorsements from the liberal media are only matched by the enthusiasm of disillusioned Conservatives. And Obama, on his part, is playing the presidential part with such effortless perfection, as if every debate, every stump speech, is an Inauguration. Well, Obama is historic and McCain is historical. It’s worth asking, how has he come so far, and so fast? The answer is not about the possibilities of the American Dream alone. It is more about playing politics differently, about stepping out of the arena of politics-as-usual and playing out the script of individuality and innovation. Change, he said, and the oldest cliché in politics got a meaning—and a context. When he identified his opponent, it was not McCain, an honourable soldier, but George W. Bush (whose unpopularity continues to be Obama’s biggest asset and the Republican challenger’s biggest handicap). He made ‘superior intellect’ compatible with a contemporary politician. When the cracks on capitalism frightened America, he didn’t panic; he didn’t offer a magic formula; he didn’t talk like a reckless, anti-rich liberal; he just identified the current regime as the cause. Most daringly, he has not fallen into the race trap: there is no angry Black in the fray. He has changed politics—a great victory even if he doesn’t get a chance to change America.



SAURABH SINGH



FROZEN: The *Vikramaditya* drydocked in Murmansk

Gorshkov in Knots

DELHI The Finance Ministry has shot down a proposal from the Ministry of Defence to consider a \$1.2-billion hike in the refit costs of aircraft carrier *Vikramaditya* (the former Russian *Admiral Gorshkov*). This is the second time the proposal has been sent back since Russia nearly doubled the refit costs of the 44,500-tonne aircraft carrier last year and indicated a four-year delay in delivery, from 2008 to 2012. Wary of the price hike setting a bad precedent for other defence deals, the Finance Ministry has questioned the emergence of a \$600-million cost for the year-

long sea trials set to begin in 2011. The impasse comes at a time when Sevmarsh, the Arctic shipyard where the carrier is being refitted, is readying to take the ship out of the drydock and moor it at a pier for installing engines and heavy machinery. Sevmarsh has asked for more funds from the Indian Government, which has paid over two-thirds of the original refit cost but frozen payments since January 2007. It seems unlikely that the *Vikramaditya* imbroglio will be resolved before the state visit of President Dmitri Medvedev in December.

by Sandeep Unnithan

Kannada Quest

BANGALORE Chief Minister B.S. Yeddyurappa, who loves Kannada folk and religious songs, wants all state legislators and MPs to pressure the Centre for granting classical language status to Kannada. Yeddyurappa’s inspiration came from Tamil Nadu, which pressured the Centre four years ago and got Tamil the status of a classical language.

Classical language status is given to a language that is at least 1,500 years old and is an original tongue. The status is currently enjoyed by Sanskrit, Tamil, Pali and Prakrit. It helps scholars and researchers in getting special grants from the governments.

The fact that the latest Man Booker prize winner Aravind Adiga is also a Kannadiga is certain to go in favour of Yeddyurappa’s demand.

by Stephen David